

Common Application Prompts and Guidelines

- 1. Some students have a background, identity, interest, or talent that is so meaningful they believe their application would be incomplete without it. If this sounds like you, then please share your story.**

Interpreting the prompt:

- Focus on the keywords 'background', 'identity', 'interest', and 'talent' and use them as launch points for your brainstorming.
- What about your history, personality, hobbies, or accomplishments might be worth highlighting for an admissions officer? It can be something as small as watching a television series or as large as the struggle of moving to a foreign country.
- The most important thing to consider for this prompt is that your subject matter and/or perspective is dynamic and specific to you and who you are, and no one else.

Some questions to ask yourself:

- What about my history or background sets me apart from my peers?
- How do I define myself? How do the people who are closest to me define me?
- What have I achieved that has been integral in molding my character and ambitions?
- What in my life so far has helped shape the person I am today?

Examples to consider:

- a. Has your family's love of food and your resultant adventurous tastes and culinary curiosity allowed you to connect with cultures from around the world?
- b. Does your crazy, dyed-blue hair define you?
- c. Did going to a Picasso exhibit inspire you to start an art collection that has since expanded beyond the borders of your bedroom?
- d. Have your yearly trips to see your extended family in China revealed something to you about your parents' ability to overcome challenges and the work ethic you have absorbed as a result?
- e. What are the challenges and rewards of having same-sex parents? Or of being raised by your siblings? Or of being part of a family made up of stepsisters and stepbrothers?
- f. Overall, this prompt is what you could call a 'choose-your-own-adventure' prompt. It has historically served as a fabulous catch-all for subjects that don't fit within the confines of the other prompts.

2. The lessons we take from obstacles we encounter can be fundamental to later success. Recount a time when you faced a challenge, setback, or failure. How did it affect you, and what did you learn from the experience?

Interpreting the prompt:

- Essays about overcoming obstacles tend to be most effective when they focus more on solutions than problems. Focus your essay on your response, outlook, and demeanor when presented with one of life's many hurdles, and aim to showcase qualities like resilience, determination, and humility.
- The obstacles you choose to explore can vary widely in nature. They can be as serious as being tormented by bullies, as ingrained as the financial issues that have plagued your family for years, or as seemingly pedestrian as a mistake that costs you a tip while waiting tables.
- Be careful not to choose challenges that may seem trite (the inability to achieve an A on an exam and/or secure tickets to that Drake concert) or that illustrate a lapse in good judgment (that time you crashed your car or ate 15 bags of Cheetos in one sitting).
- If you can isolate an incident of trial in your life and how you learned from it, this can be a rewarding prompt to explore.

Some questions to ask yourself:

- How do you deal with hardship?
- What qualifies as a challenge or setback in your life and world?
- Are you the kind of person who can rebound—who turns every experience, good or bad, into one from which you can learn something? What experiences might illustrate this quality?
- What have been some of the major challenges you've encountered in your life, and was there a silver lining?

Examples to consider:

1. Has a lifelong battle with stuttering ultimately increased your overall confidence and allowed you to participate in social activities and public forums without self-judgment?
2. Did a parent's fragile health situation challenge you to take on more responsibilities than the average teenager?
3. Did a series of setbacks on your road to becoming a child actor introduce you to screenwriting, your professional goal, and your biggest passion?
4. Did your failure to follow directions lead you to a botched home science experiment (root beer explosion!) and an appreciation for a balance of creativity and planned procedure?

3. Reflect on a time when you questioned or challenged a belief or idea. What prompted your thinking? What was the outcome?

Interpreting the prompt:

- This prompt requires you to speak passionately about beliefs and ideology, which are often onerous subjects that can be difficult to mold into compact stories. • It can be one of the hardest questions to steer in a positive, productive direction without traveling into the preachy, overly didactic territory.
- This is also a more precarious prompt than most in that students need to carefully assess the risks of espousing beliefs that might be polarizing for the readers of their applications.
- That said, a response to this prompt can be incisive and deeply personal, as it was for a student who stood up to her parents' old-fashioned outlook on feminism. Applicants who can articulate their thoughts and feelings while showcasing malleability and willingness to thoughtfully consider the ideas of others will likely stand out as valuable additions to any campus.
- If this prompt jumps out at you because you have a very specific story to tell or an opinion to voice, run with it!
- Your essay does not have to be focused on a fundamentally serious or ground-breaking issue. What matters most when responding to this prompt is that you have strong convictions about the belief or idea you are trying to convey and that you examine the personal effects of this ethos on your life and world. For this reason, this prompt can be a great vehicle for showcasing your consideration, persuasive skills, and passion to admissions.

Some questions to ask yourself:

- When has your opinion been unpopular?
- Why are you the kind of person who is willing to stand up for what you believe in?
- What is important to you on a fundamental level of morals and values?
- How passionate are you about the things you believe in?

Examples to consider:

1. Are you openly gay in a strict Catholic school environment, and what has that meant for your self-esteem and personal relationships?
2. Did you work as an intern on a political campaign caught at the center of a scandal? How did you react?
3. Did you challenge the idea of horror as a throwaway genre by executing an extensive research paper on the subject, launching a horror movie club at school, and arranging the most elaborate, best-received haunted house your neighborhood has ever seen?

4. Reflect on something that someone has done for you that has made you happy or thankful in a surprising way. How has this gratitude affected or motivated you?

Interpreting the prompt:

- This prompt was inspired by research on gratitude and kindness, and on the positive influence others have on our lives, so write about how you have been affected or motivated to do something, rather than the thing someone has done for you. Consider your response and reaction, showcasing what you learned from the experience.
- Your response should be heartfelt and sincere. You should, however, be wary of veering off on a preachy tangent or writing a sob story. Make the focus on your ability to write about your thoughts and feelings, and your willingness to learn from others to be a better person.
- Be careful when choosing your example - it shouldn't be something that may seem superficial or not meaningful, like being bought an expensive gift or being given a compliment. Your example should be something that has helped make you a better person or see the world in a new light.

Some questions to ask yourself:

- Who do you consider to be a positive influence in your life and how have they affected you or made you want to do better?
- Has anything happened to you recently that has changed the way you think about others?
- As a result of something someone did for you, over the last few months or years, how has your worldview developed, and how have you grown as a person?
- Have you learned something from someone else recently that has made you feel more passionate about a cause, or inspired you to do something meaningful?

Examples to consider:

1. Has someone you don't know helped out you or a family member - financially or otherwise - which inspired you to pay it forward?
2. Because you received similar help, have you started bringing extra lunch to school to help out someone who has less than you?
3. Have you started doing things for other people - even when you don't want to - because you noticed someone in your life always makes small sacrifices for you (like listening to you even though they're tired, or helping you with something when they're already busy)?
4. Have you stood up for someone - even if you don't know them very well - because someone unexpectedly did the same for you?
5. Have you taken the time to get to know someone who doesn't have a friendship group, because you were once new to the school as well and had someone

5. Discuss an accomplishment, event, or realization that sparked a period of personal growth and a new understanding of yourself or others.

Interpreting the prompt:

- Keep in mind that the words ‘accomplishment’ and ‘event’ leave themselves open to interpretation; thus, an essay inspired by this question can tackle anything from a formal event to a very small occurrence.
- A formal event or accomplishment might include anything from obvious landmarks like birthdays or weddings to achievements like earning an award or receiving a promotion.
- More informal examples might include something as simple as meeting a special person in your life, taking a car ride, or eating a particularly meaningful meal.
- Often smaller, less formal events make for more surprising and memorable essays, but as with any of the other prompts, as long as you can answer with originality and put a unique twist on your subject matter, all ideas, formal or informal, big or small, are fair game.
- Your reflection on what you learned and how you grew will be a source of great insight for admissions, and you want to make sure your essay highlights the intangible qualities that don’t show up anywhere else on an application.
- The most important thing to keep in mind when searching for these moments is the element of growth, understanding, and transformation. The event, accomplishment, or realization you discuss should be something that helped you understand the world around you through a different, more mature lens. And as ever, be sure to answer all parts of the question.

Some questions to ask yourself:

- How do you react to periods of transition? What inspires a change in your perspective?
- When have you had a “eureka” moment, and how has it impacted the way you lived your life thereafter?
- What were the moments in life that fundamentally changed you as a person?
- When did you learn something that made you feel more adult, more capable, more grown up?

Examples to consider:

1. Did your expansion of a handmade stationery hobby into a full-fledged business give you the motivation and wherewithal to combat the effects of a debilitating illness?
2. Have you learned to love the football team playback sessions that force you to routinely examine your mistakes but also to welcome constructive criticism and point yourself toward self-improvement?
3. Did a summer-long role as the U.S. President in a mock government and

4. What did playing bridge at a senior citizens' home each week show you about the value of enjoyment over competition? How did this change the way you interact and connect with others?

6. Describe a topic, idea, or concept you find so engaging that it makes you lose all track of time. Why does it captivate you? What or who do you turn to when you want to learn more?

Interpreting the prompt:

- College, one could argue, is largely about the pursuit of knowledge, so you can imagine it would be quite appealing for an admissions officer to have a meter for your level of self-motivated learning, along with a better understanding of how and why you choose to pay attention to the things that intrigue you.
- This is a full-on peek into your brain: how you process information, and how you seek out new sources of content and inspiration. How resourceful are you when your curiosity is piqued to the fullest?
- The answer to this prompt should also reveal something to admissions about the breadth or depth of your interests. For example, if you're interested in studying astrophysics, you might choose to discuss a concept that shows how far your exploration of the sciences truly reaches. How consumed are you by this passion you are choosing to pursue academically?
- Whatever you're into, embrace it. Show your feathers. Let your freak flag fly (within reason, obviously).

Some questions to ask yourself:

- What floats your boat? Do you have an appetite for knowledge about something specific? What do you love, and why do you love it?
- What lengths have you gone to to acquire new information about or experiences related to a topic of interest?
- How do you typically seek to enrich your knowledge when something appeals to you? Do you have a favorite corner or the library (or internet)? A mentor who is open to answering your burning questions?
- What about the process of learning, especially about subjects that call out to you, is satisfying?

Examples to consider:

1. Did the idea of open-source code inspire you to create a tech startup with a few of your friends? What projects do you work on, and why is the idea of sharing information still so revolutionary?

2. Did getting an internship at an accounting firm inspire you to start each day by checking the markets? Do you participate in a mock trading club that allows you to use the

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expertise you gather from culling through economic news and analysis online and beyond?

3. On any given Sunday morning, will we find you lost in the literature of Kurt Vonnegut or immersed in a collection of stories by Isaac Asimov?

4. Have you taught yourself to master the compositions of Mozart and Beethoven and break down the songs of Bruno Mars by ear in your spare time?

5. Do you have an obsession with pizza so intense it led you to study bread-making and keep a pizza journal that documents the 700+ slices you've consumed thus far? How is pizza-making more scientific and/or artistic than the average person realizes?

7. Share an essay on any topic of your choice. It can be one you've already written, one that responds to a different prompt, or one of your own design.

Interpreting the prompt:

- While being able to write about whatever you wish sounds great in theory, some students find—especially at the beginning of the brainstorming process—that they are debilitated by the ‘topic of your choice’ option because it offers too much choice.
- If that is the case, fear not! Use some of the other prompts as starting points for your brainstorming and freewriting journeys.
- Once you figure out what you'd like to say (and maybe even after you draft the crux of the essay itself), see if your concept fits one of the first six prompts. Trying to back into a more specific prompt option may inspire an interesting spin on the story you are trying to tell—one you may not have thought of otherwise.
- If, after careful consideration, your magic essay topic does not work within the confines of Prompts 1-6, you are in luck. The glorious, all-encompassing Prompt #7 will be here to catch you.

Some questions to ask yourself:

- What do you want admissions to know about you that they wouldn't be able to glean from your transcript, test scores, or teacher recommendations?
- What are the stories that come up over and over again, at the dinner table or in the cafeteria with your friends, that might give admissions some insight into who you are and what is important to you?
- If you had ten minutes alone in a room with an admissions officer, what would you want to talk about or tell him or her about yourself?

- What would you bring to a college campus that no one else would or

could? Examples to consider:

1. Were you born with a congenital eye defect that literally (and metaphorically) affects how you see the world? (Q: How is your perspective on the world unique?)
2. Do you spend 40 minutes each Friday night tutoring a class of elementary school students in Cambodia? How has that impacted the way you manage your time and assess your commitments? (Q: What is the value of 40 minutes?)
3. Did your parents let your older brother choose your name? What was his inspiration? What does your name represent for you? How has it impacted your interactions in the world? (Q: What's in a name?)